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In 1870, Christopher Columbus Langdell introduced the case method of teaching at Harvard, and dramatically altered the course of legal education in the United States. His method, involving student examination of judicial decisions coupled with Socratic style analysis, ultimately gained widespread acceptance. Today, most US law teachers use the case method. They continue, to varying degrees, to use Socratic questioning as part of that method. But, despite the method's widespread adoption, it has always had critics including both law students and law teachers.

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